

THE KEEPERS



OF MORDRIN

The Keepers of Mordrin

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The Keepers of Mordrin

Chapter 1: The Ship to Alaron

The large wooden ship, *The Salty Clam*, rocked back and forth on the bright blue waves of the Sea of Swords. It was sailing to the island of Alaron. Four strangers sat on the wide deck. They didn't know it yet, but they were about to become the best of friends.

The first was Aknemeia. She was a tiefling, with pale skin, bright red hair, and two curved black horns on her head. Faint gold scales on her arms hinted at her mysterious past. She watched the sea quietly with golden eyes, preferring to keep to herself. Magic fire sparked playfully at her fingertips like little, colorful fireflies when she got lost in thought.

Next to her stood Eryneth, a wood elf whose pointed ears were visible beneath her pale white hair. Eryneth held a beautifully carved long wooden bow in her hands. She was a master at archery and surviving in the wild, but around other people she often felt shy and unsure of herself. Eryneth nervously adjusted her soft green cloak, trying her best to blend in.

On a tall barrel sat Szeth. He was a bald young human who wore plain white clothes and could move incredibly fast. Szeth always said exactly what he was thinking, even if it was a little rude or awkward. "This boat is very slow," Szeth announced loudly to no

one in particular, crossing his arms.

Finally, there was Caryndal. He was a half-elf who wore armor and a green cloak. He loved playing his sweet-sounding lute and creating beautiful, theatrical illusions. With a graceful wave of his hand, a glowing butterfly fluttered around Szeth's head.

"Patience, speedy one," Caryndal chuckled. His voice was playful. "The journey is part of the fun!" They had been traveling on the sea for a few days now, but had hardly spoken. Each had been lost in their own thoughts.

A loud, complaining voice suddenly broke the silence. "Is there no food on this miserable tub that isn't completely covered in salt?"

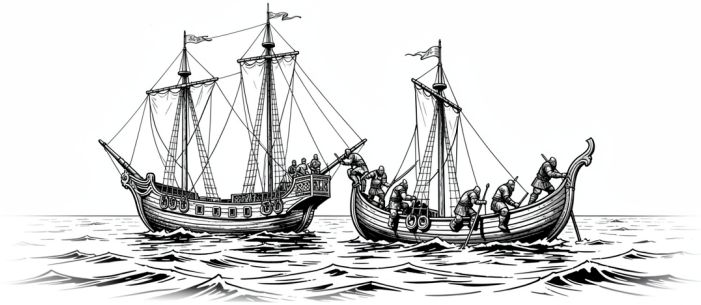
A young boy marched across the deck. He was wearing uncomfortably heavy, fancy velvet clothes that looked far too hot for a sea voyage. He stopped in front of the four strangers, pointing his nose high in the air.

"I am Gregory Kendrick," he announced, as if they should all be very impressed. "And I expect far better treatment than this. Someone go tell the captain to fetch me a fresh apple!"

"What you are is loud," Szeth remarked.

Gregory's face turned as red as his velvet coat, but before he could respond, a shout echoed from above.

The ship lookout called to the captain. "Sir, a ship is coming. It's the *Grey Wolf*! It's Northmen raiders!"



Suddenly, a loud *THUMP* shook the entire ship. Gregory tumbled backward into some wooden crates. He hit the deck with a yelp, but quickly scrambled to his feet, dusting off his coat with an annoyed huff.

Before any of them could tell him to be quiet, another shout echoed from the lookout. "Here they come!"

The long Northmen ship had crashed up against the *Salty Clam*, and raiders were gathering on the other side.

"Captain Ulfrik, we're ready to board!" a raider cheered from the other deck.

"For Norland!" yelled a big man with a large beard, as he jumped over to their ship. They could see from his clothes that he was the so-called Ulfrik, captain of the raiders. "Your ship is ours now!" he boomed with a loud laugh.

Gregory squeezed his eyes shut and covered his ears in fear. Ulfrik's eyes locked right onto him. "Ah, just who I was looking for!" the huge raider bellowed, scooping the boy up.

"My mother won't let you get away with this!" Gregory yelled, struggling in the raider's grip.

The four strangers looked at each other, and then at the struggling boy. They didn't need to say a word. It was time to work together to save the ship and drive off the raiders.

"I will handle the big one," Szeth said, leaping off the barrel and flipping through the air.

He landed right in front of the captain, trying to rescue the boy. Ulfrik grunted in surprise, stepping back but keeping a tight grip on the boy. "Leave this ship alone!" Aknemeia shouted, clapping her hands together.

A burst of bright red sparks zoomed at the raiders, making them cover their eyes. Eryneth drew her bow. *Twang! Twang!* She shot two arrows perfectly. They pinned the raiders' shirts right to the wooden mast of their ship!

The raiders wiggled, stuck in place. Caryndal laughed and played his lute. He cast a grand illusion. Suddenly, it looked like a giant, glowing sea monster was rising out of the water. "Sea monster, run!" yelled one raider. Others began to run away in panic.

Ulfrik snarled as his crew ran away. "This is too much trouble! Leave the treasures and get back to our ship! We have the boy!" he yelled. He swung back to his own ship, taking the boy with him. "Retreat!" The *Grey Wolf* ship quickly sailed away, leaving the four heroes standing together on the deck of the *Salty Clam*.

Eryneth lowered her bow, feeling a little braver but worried. Aknemeia gave Szeth a supportive nod. Caryndal played a serious, determined tune on his lute. The ship was safe from the raiders, but they felt there was something else going on. The four of them looked at each other.

"Well," said Caryndal. "I think we work together pretty well, don't you?"

"We have to go after him," Eryneth said quietly, her sharp elven

eyes looking out at the retreating raiders. "That boy, Gregory. The raiders took him."

"He was annoying, but I agree," said Szeth.

"Agreed," Aknemeia said, adjusting her cloak. "But where? They sailed off into the open ocean. We need a lead, and a plan."

Chapter 2: Arrival at Carraigport

The *Salty Clam* bumped gently against the wooden docks of Carraigport. They had made it. But the victory felt hollow.

The town of Carraigport was small and bustling, smelling strongly of fish, salt, and wet wood. Gulls cried overhead as sailors unloaded crates from docked ships. The group made their way through the busy morning market, their stomachs rumbling, until they found a cozy tavern called The Hefty Pint. Inside, a roaring fire crackled in the hearth, and a plump, cheerful man was wiping down tables.

"Welcome, travelers!" the innkeeper called out. "I'm Silas. Best breakfast in Carraigport, guaranteed!"

Szeth sniffed the air. "It smells like burned porridge... and aren't you the only tavern in town?"

Silas blinked, his cheerful smile freezing.

"What my friend means," Caryndal jumped in smoothly, flashing a dazzling smile, "is that we are simply overwhelmed by your town's quaint, rustic charm and the rich aroma of toasted porridge! We'll take four bowls."

They sat down, discussing the raiders and the missing boy. No sooner had they started to eat than an elderly man approached their table. He wore fine clothes that hung loose on his elderly frame, and he had deep worry lines etched into his forehead.



"Excuse me," the man said, wringing his hands. "Are you the heroes who fought off those raiders? The whole dock is buzzing about you."

"Indeed, we are the *Clamshell Avengers*," Caryndal announced, standing and taking a dramatic bow.

Szeth looked at Caryndal. "I think avenging the *Salty Clam* was a one-time thing. We need something more epic."

"I... I am Laird Marvyn, the leader of this town," the man said,

looking confused. "We need your help. Desperately."

"We're already on a mission," Aknemeia said, her golden eyes narrowing. "We're looking for a captured boy."

Laird Marvyn's eyes widened. "Gregory Kendrick? The one the raiders captured? We may be able to help you contact his mother, or at least put you in touch the authorities. But we can pay you for your services if you're willing to help us first."

With that, the group leaned in with interest.

"My town," Laird Marvyn said in a low voice, "is in danger. Every night, we have been hearing spooky sounds coming from the outskirts of the woods, and people have been disappearing. We are out of our depth."

Szeth crossed his arms. "Are you too old to do it yourself?"

Caryndal sighed loudly. "Szeth, please have some tact." He turned back to the Laird with a smile. "Where did you say these sounds were coming from?"

"Near an old farm at the edge of the woods," the Laird repeated. "It belongs Suhlur, a mage who moved here a few years ago from the capital city. He used to be friendly with the townsfolk, but he

hasn't spoken to anyone in months. People have grown afraid of the noises. Please, will you investigate?"

"We have a deal," Eryneth agreed firmly.

The walk to Suhlur's property took them through a patch of dense woods. By the time they reached the old farm, the sun was beginning to set, casting long shadows across the ground.

Suhlur's house sat in the middle of an overgrown field. It was totally silent.



"This place feels wrong," Aknemeia whispered, snapping her fingers. A small magical flame danced in her hand, casting a warm glow in the twilight.

The front door was locked tight, but a quick kick from Szeth popped it open with a loud *CRACK*. The heroes stepped inside, coughing as dust swirled around them. The house was a mess. Strange symbols were scratched into the floorboards, and the air smelled like old, stale earth. Eryneth quickly spotted a messy desk in the corner. Scattered across it were notes covered in magical writing.

"Look," Eryneth pointed out the window. "There's barn out back. Just behind the house."

Suddenly, a loud *THUMP* echoed from the shadows.

A figure lurched out from the dark hallway. It was a zombie, shuffling and groaning as it walked towards them.

"Zombie!" Caryndal said, grabbing his lute and strumming a chord. Magical energy flowed from the lute strings, protecting his friends.

The zombie lunged, its arms outstretched. But the heroes were ready.

Szeth darted forward, faster than lightning, and delivered a spinning kick to the zombie. Aknemeia sent a bright blast of fire that singed the zombie's ragged cloak. Before the creature could recover, Eryneth smoothly drew an arrow, aimed, and fired.

THWACK!

The arrow pinned the zombie's sleeve firmly to the thick wooden doorframe. It groaned, wiggling helplessly against the wood, unable to break free. The fight was over in seconds.

"Well," Caryndal said, dusting off his hands. "That was delightfully spooky, but not very effective."

"Suhlur left it here on purpose," Aknemeia said, inspecting the magical notes on the desk. "He's been making these spooky zombies with dark magic."

"If there's one here," Eryneth said perfectly calmly, pointing out the window toward the backyard, "there might be more in that barn."

The barn stood at the edge of the property, its enormous wooden

doors shut tight. The spooky sounds Laird Marvyn had mentioned were much louder now. Muffled groans and the rattling of wood drifted out from inside.

Eryneth carefully pushed the heavy barn doors open. The hinges squealed.

Inside, the barn didn't hold cows or horses. Instead, there were rows of large, wooden cages. Inside the cages, dozens of shadowy figures shuffled and groaned. It was a whole room full of zombies!

"Suhlur hasn't just been making one zombie," Caryndal whispered, his eyes wide. "He's making an army!"

"This is bad," Aknemeia said, her hands sparking with nervous energy.

"Can we fix them? Does anyone have any un-zombie potion?" Szeth asked.

"I'm not sure," Aknemeia said, putting a hand on his shoulder. "But they aren't going anywhere right now. We need to stop the person making them. We need to find Suhlur."

Caryndal puffed out his chest and smiled, a sudden glint in his

eye. He waved his hands in a wide, sweeping motion. With a burst of fey magic, a shimmering, glowing banner appeared in the air above their heads. It crackled with bright, colorful sparkles, illuminating the dark barn with the words "Clamshell Avengers".

"Fear not, citizens of Carraigport!" Caryndal declared dramatically, pitching his voice so it echoed through the barn.

"Your rescuers are here! We will find this dark wizard, defeat his army, and save the day!" The zombies groaned in response.

"That name is still no good," said Szeth. "There's no way shells are important." But he stood proud anyway. They had a dark wizard to find and people to rescue... hopefully.

As the flickering light of Caryndal's magic lit the corners of the barn, Erynth suddenly pointed. "There!"

Chapter 3: The Mad Wizard

Eryneth had spotted footprints in the dirt. The group followed her, while Aknemeia's flickering magic fire lit the way. "How can you all see in this dark?" Szeth complained.

"Elves can see perfectly fine," Eryneth explained.

"Tieflings, too," said Aknemeia.

"Half-elf," said Caryndal, shrugging, "on my father's side."

Szeth frowned, but followed them anyway. He only stubbed his toe once in the dark.

The trail led out of the barn and to a hidden trapdoor. Beneath it, a set of stone stairs led down into a basement. Dust coated the steps, and the air smelled heavy with stale dirt and strange magic.



"Stay close," Eryneth whispered, keeping an arrow notched in her bow. "Whatever is making those zombies is down here."

Aknemeia hissed, pointing at the glowing light at the bottom of the stairs. "Look!"

They crept into a wide, dusty basement that looked like a laboratory. Bubbling potions simmered in glass jars, and magical trinkets littered long wooden tables. In the center of the room stood an old man in black robes. He clutched a dark, twisted wooden staff with a black crystal on it. On his shoulder sat a ragged raven zombie.

"Who dares enter!" the old man shouted, his voice cracking. He pointed his staff at them. "I am Suhlur! My master, Kazgoroth, does not tolerate your meddling!"

The raven let out a loud *CAW!* and flew straight at Caryndal!

"I don't think so!" Caryndal called out. He quickly strummed his fingers on his lute, casting a brilliant spell. With a loud *POP*, a glowing, magical cage appeared in the air around the raven.

Squawk! The raven bounced harmlessly off the magical bars, trapped and defeated in an instant.

"Mordrin! No!" Suhlur wailed, looking at his trapped bird. Then, his eyes narrowed, and the magical energies in the room began to swirl. "You will pay for that!"

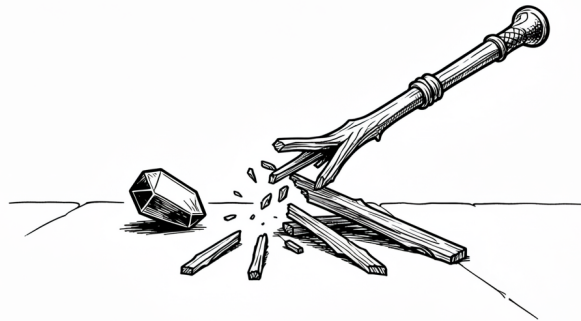
"Your posture is terrible, old wizard!" Szeth yelled. He leaped across the room, far faster than typical humans, dodging a spark of green magic that Suhlur fired. Szeth landed perfectly in front of the wizard and delivered a swift, powerful kick right to the wooden staff.

Suhlur stumbled backward, trying to cast another spell, but Aknemeia was ready. She slammed her hands together, throwing a ball of bright, warm fire that collided with Suhlur's green magic, dissolving it with a loud *SIZZLE*.

"Now, Eryneth!" Caryndal shouted.

Eryneth drew her bow back and fired. Her arrow sailed through the air and hit Suhlur's dark staff perfectly in the middle.

CRACK!



The staff shattered into a dozen pieces. One of them was a chunk of black, jagged crystal. It clattered to the stone floor.

Then, the dark green magical lights in the basement vanished. Suhlur gasped, and his eyes widened. He slumped backward onto the floor, all the fight leaving him instantly.

Aknemeia slowly walked toward the broken shards of the staff. The black crystal pulsed with cold energy. It seemed to whisper to Aknemeia, offering her dark power. She hesitated a moment, but Aknemeia shook her head. She took out a thick cloth and

wrapped it tightly inside. The whispering immediately stopped.

"I think the spell is broken," Aknemeia sighed in relief.

A suddenly normal-looking Mordrin squawked inside his cage. From upstairs, a massive commotion broke out in the barn. The groans of the zombies in the barn had been replaced by loud talking.

"The magic!" Caryndal cheered. "Without the staff, the zombies have turned back into normal people!"

Suhlur looked up at the heroes, tears welling in his tired eyes. He didn't look like a mad wizard anymore. He just looked like a sad, exhausted old man.

"You did it," Suhlur rasped, pointing a shaky finger at the wrapped stone in Aknemeia's hands. "You broke its hold on me. Thank you."

"Why were you making zombies, Suhlur?" Eryneth asked gently, lowering her bow.

"It was the Shard," Suhlur explained quietly, leaning heavily on his desk. "Long ago, the great High Queen Alicia defeated a terrible beast named Kazgoroth. I was one of the Queen's trusted

friends who helped her. She asked me to keep that Shard safe, and hide its dark magic from the world. But... it was too strong. Over the years, it twisted my thoughts towards evil. Without you, I would have been lost forever."

"The Queen did that?" Caryndal said in awe.

Suhlur nodded slowly, his eyes heavy. "Yes. It ended a long conflict with the Northmen, but that is a story for another time. For now, the Shard of Kazgoroth must be secured. We must contact the Queen. It is far too dangerous." He breathed heavily. "I am... so very tired."

Within seconds, the old wizard was fast asleep, snoring softly in his chair.

"He owes us answers when he wakes," Eryneth said, looking at the bundle in Aknemeia's hands. "This seems important."

"And what about Gregory?" Szeth asked crossing his arms. "The captured boy."

Caryndal adjusted his cloak, striking a heroic pose. "Everyone, relax. We just won the day! We need a name before we return to town. The Dazzling Defenders? The Fearsome Four? You didn't like Clamshell Avengers."

"The Danger Punchers," Szeth suggested. "Because we punch danger."

"Definitely not, but the name can wait," Erynth said. "For now, we have to return to Laird Marvyn."

"Fair enough," said Szeth, "but I'm keeping the bird. I think he likes me."

Chapter 4: The Queen's Mission

The heroes led a very tired Suhlur, along with the missing townspeople, out of the woods and back into the town of Carraigport. Laird Marvyn was waiting in his office, pacing back and forth nervously. When he saw them return with the old wizard and the dark crystal wrapped tightly in cloth, he nearly fainted with relief.

"You really did it!" the Laird gasped. "The missing people!"

"We did," Caryndal said, giving a sweeping bow. "It was quite heroic."

Suhlur leaned heavily against the Laird's large wooden desk. "I must contact the High Queen," he rasped, his voice weak. "She needs to know what has happened to her dangerous Shard."

Suhlur lifted a shaky hand and chanted a few strange, magical words. The air above the desk began to shimmer and glow with a soft blue light. Suddenly, the glowing light formed the shape of a regal woman wearing a beautiful crown. It was High Queen Alicia Kendrick, communicating with them through the magical spell!

The Queen looked back at them through the spell. "Suhlur? Is that you? What has happened?"



Eryneth stepped forward bravely. "Your Majesty, we rescued Suhlur. He was being controlled by the dark magic of the Shard of Kazgoroth and making zombies. We broke the spell, but the shard is dangerous."

"Yes," Aknemeia added, stepping next to Eryneth. "The crystal is safe for now. I wrapped it up so it can't whisper to anyone anymore."

The Queen's shoulders relaxed a little, and she offered them a grateful smile. "You handled the Shard without falling to its temptation? That is truly brave. Thank you all for keeping my people safe."

"We are happy to help," Szeth stated. "But there is another problem. A boy named Gregory was captured by raiders."

The Queen gasped with surprise. "Gregory? My son! The raiders took him?"

The heroes looked at each other in shock. The bossy boy from the ship was the Queen's son?!

"We saw the man who took him," Caryndal said gently. "His name was Ulfrik. His ship, the *Grey Wolf*, sailed away."

"Ulfrik," the Queen growled, her voice full of worry and anger. "I knew him. He is a Northman warrior. Perhaps this has something to do with our old conflict with his people. Long ago, Kazgoroth deceived them into conflict with our kingdom. I was able to bind Kazgoroth inside the shards with the help of Suhlur and Audrin. We each carry a shard, guarding them." She looked at Suhlur with a sad expression. "Or at least, we did. I am sorry, old friend."

"Wait," Szeth interrupted. "If you are so powerful, why didn't you just defeat Kazgoroth instead of sticking him in crystals?"

Caryndal hissed at Szeth, elbowing him to be quiet, but the Queen just offered a sad, tired smile.

"Because we couldn't," the Queen admitted. "We didn't have the necessary magic or tools to do so. The best we could do was bind the beast inside the shards." Her expression turned serious again. "Let us return to the present. I cannot leave my kingdom without its Queen to chase Ulfrik, and I cannot leave Suhlur's Shard, nor my own shard, unprotected. Please, brave heroes, I officially hire you. Will you help me rescue my son as you rescued Suhlur?"

Caryndal puffed out his chest, stepping right into the middle of the glowing blue light. "Do not worry, Your Majesty! You can count on... The Shard Snatchers?"

The illusion of the Queen blinked slowly, looking confused.

"That name is even worse than the last one," Szeth grumbled, crossing his arms. "We are not snatching shards. We only snatched one shard, and we don't even want it."

"There is one problem, your Majesty," Eryneth said, interrupting her friends. "We don't know where Ulfrik was headed."

"I know where to start," Alicia said. "After the conflict with the Northmen ended, Ulfrik and many of his people made a home on the island of Mintarn. I traveled there in my younger years. It is a... colorful place, full of pirates and scoundrels, and a wild forest."

"We'll be on our guard, your highness," Caryndal said with a bow. "And we'll find your son."

"Thank you, and rest well," said the image of the Queen. "For tomorrow, you set sail."

The next morning, the group boarded a swift new ship headed across the sea. The days on the water gave the new friends time to learn more about each other.

Eryneth spent her days practicing her archery. She set up small wooden targets on the railing of the ship and hit the bullseye every single time with a satisfying *thwack!* Aknemeia watched the ocean waves, her innate magic warming the chilly sea breeze around her. She seemed to be deep in thought, but Eryneth did not ask why.

But not everyone was relaxing.

"Why does your ship take so long?" Szeth announced loudly to the ship's Captain, pointing at the large sails. "Can't you just get bigger sails or make the ship more pointy?"

The Captain, a bald, dark-skinned man, glared at Szeth. "More pointy?! I've sailed this ship for twenty years! Insult my ship again, and I'll throw you overboard to swim to Mintarn yourself!"

Szeth opened his mouth to say that swimming would be even slower, but Caryndal swooped over in a flash of colorful silk.

"Captain, my good man!" Caryndal laughed, wrapping an arm around the angry sailor. He used a tiny bit of Fey magic to make a beautiful, sweet-smelling flower appear in the Captain's pocket. "My friend here simply means your ship is so sturdy and grand, it barely feels like we are moving at all! A true masterpiece of the sea!"

The Captain grumbled, pulling the flower out of his pocket and sniffing it. "Well. I suppose she is a sturdy vessel. Try to keep your friend quiet, bard."

Caryndal sighed in relief, gently pushing Szeth away from the steering wheel. "Please, Szeth. We need the boat to get to the prince."

After a few more days of sailing, the salty sea air changed, smelling faintly of smoke and spices. The heroes gathered at the front of the ship. Rising up from the water was a bustling island. Its shore was covered in wooden buildings, docks, and hundreds

of ships.

They had arrived at Mintarn. The search for the prince was on!

Chapter 5: Arrival at Mintarn

It was late afternoon when the ship arrived at the busy port of Mintarn. The island was covered in wooden buildings and docks, with hundreds of ships rocking gently in the water. The salty sea breeze was mixed with the faint smells of smoke and sweet spices.



Szeth stood at the front of the ship, looking out at the island. He took a deep breath as a group of sailors walked by. "This island smells like burnt fish and old shoes," he observed.

Caryndal quickly waved his hands, a colorful swirl of illusion magic sparkling around him as he stepped in front of Szeth. "Uh,

what my friend meant to say is that it smells like... the rich aroma of adventure!" Caryndal declared theatrically to the passing sailors. He lowered his voice. "Please, Szeth. We are trying not to cause trouble right away."

They stepped off the ship and made their way through the busy streets. They passed a tavern with beautiful music coming from inside. "That sounds like a twostring!" Caryndal called to his friends. A quick look at the sign on the door confirmed his suspicions: beneath a picture of a string instrument, it read "The Twostring".

Before anyone could object, he pushed open the door.

Inside, it was cozy and welcoming. The tavern was filled with laughter and the sound of music. A friendly young man with pointed ears was playing a unique musical instrument on stage. It had a long wooden neck with two strings. He plucked at them as he told a wonderful story of elves, magic, and faeries.

After his song finished, the musician spotted them and came over to their table. "Welcome to The Twostring! I am Florian," he said, holding his instrument tightly. "I am the innkeeper here. But to be honest, I am having a very terrible day. You all look like the type who could help a pal out."

"Why?" asked Aknemeia, her golden eyes watching him carefully.

Instead of answering right away, Caryndal gently strummed his lute. He muttered a quick spell, and a tiny, sparkling illusion of a pixie began to dance on their table. "A beautiful song," Caryndal hummed. "It deserves a proper visual."

Florian gasped in delight. "I thought I recognized Fae magic. You have the touch of the faery realm... I knew I chose the right group. Please, you must listen to my story."

Florian sighed, looking around to make sure no one else was listening. "A gang of local thieves, run by Idruz, have taken my younger sister. My family back home is very wealthy, you see. Idruz found out, and her gang captured her for ransom! I have been trying to keep my family secret. I just want to enjoy playing my music here on Mintarn, but now my sister is in danger."

The heroes looked at each other.

"We will rescue her," Eryneth said, finding her courage.

"Yeah," replied Szeth. "We have a thing about rescuing captured people. It seems to be our favorite pastime."

"Excellent!" Caryndal clapped his hands together. "You can count on us! We are... The Sibling Savers!"

Szeth frowned. "That's no good either. We're not even her siblings, so it doesn't make sense."

Caryndal sighed. "Oh well. So... where is your sister, Florian?"

Florian pointed toward the docks. "They took her to one of the old warehouses near the water."

The heroes snuck out of the tavern and down to the docks as the sun began to set. They easily found the old warehouse, with several of Idruz's gruff-looking thieves standing guard outside.

"What now?" whispered Aknemeia, conjuring a spark in her hand.

Caryndal grinned. "How about a performance?" he said as he strummed his lute. Suddenly, the loud, booming sound of marching boots echoed down the street. It sounded like an entire squad of angry town guards! He used his magic to make bright torches appear in the distance.

Idruz's guards jumped in surprise. "Guards are coming! Hide!" one of them shouted. Most of the thieves scrambled away into the shadows.

Suddenly, the leader of the thieves kicked open the warehouse door. "Cowards! It's a trick!" she yelled at her fleeing guards. "I am Idruz, and you won't ruin my plans!"

She moved to go after the heroes, but Eryneth was too fast. She fired an arrow, knocking a heavy wooden sign off the wall above. It crashed down, knocking the bandit leader off balance. Before Idruz could recover, Aknemeia sent a bright spark of fire that made Idruz jump back in surprise.

In the moment of confusion, Szeth darted into the warehouse, quickly locating Florian's surprised sister. A short moment later, he dashed right out with her in tow.

"We're here with your brother," Szeth stated. "Trust us."

As the heroes regrouped and began to run, Idruz scrambled to her feet, shaking her fist at them. "This isn't over!" she howled. "I swear vengeance on all of you!" She tried to stumble after them, but the sparks from Aknemeia's spell and the rubble from the sign tripped her up.

As quickly as it had begun, it was over.

Back at The Twostring, Florian was overjoyed. He hugged his sister tightly. "Thank you! Thank you so much!" he cheered. "You are true heroes. How can I ever repay you?"

"We are looking for a Northman named Ulfrik," Aknemeia explained. "And a young boy named Gregory."

Florian's eyes widened into a smile. "I know someone who can help. I'll take you to see him tomorrow. For now, let's eat!"

The next morning, Florian took them to a tea shop, *The Jade Dragon*.

"Allow me to introduce you to Malthos, the keeper of tea and secrets on the island," Florian said, opening the door of the shop to reveal walls covered in tea jars of all shapes and sizes. "He knows everything that happens on Mintarn."



Behind the counter of the shop was an older tiefling man with red skin, long curved horns, and keen eyes. Malthos looked closely at the group, his gaze stopping on Aknemeia. He smiled a small, knowing smile.

"Good to see you again, young one," Malthos said softly. "I see you are walking a different path from your father."

"Malthos?" said Aknemeia, surprised. "You remember me? It has been so long since you left my father's... organization."

"I remember much, young lady, and I'm glad to see that you are well," Malthos said softly. "Perhaps we can catch up when your work here is done. For now, Florian tells me you are in a hurry."

Aknemeia stood tall, and a spark glowed in her eyes. "Yes," she

said. "We're looking for a Northman named Ulfrik."

Malthos nodded gravely. "Ulfrik is well known here. He and his Northmen clan bring their ship to port here often. He talks to the locals about justice and honor for his people. He promises that they will have justice against Kazgoroth, who deceived them long ago."

Aknemeia gasped softly. "Queen Alicia told us about how they bound Kazgoroth to the shards, but what is Ulfrik planning? Why would he need the prince?"

"I'm not sure," Malthos explained apologetically. "He and his men came through town with the young boy. They had an elf mage with them. I think his name was Audrin."

"Audrin!" Caryndal exclaimed. "I recognize that name. He helped Queen Alicia trap Kazgoroth inside the shards in the first place! Why would he work with Ulfrik?"

"That I don't know," said Malthos, "but I do know they were headed deep into the Great Forest, and that they were looking for a sword."

"Oh!" said Eryneth her ears perking up at the mention of trees. "Then I suppose it's time for a walk in the woods!"

Chapter 6: The Great Forest

The heroes left the chaos and noise of Mintarn behind and stepped into the edge of the Great Forest. The trees quickly became denser and more massive, with thick trunks covered in bright green moss and twisting vines. The air was heavy and filled with the strange sounds of chirping insects, bird calls, and rustling leaves.

Eryneth took a deep breath, a bright smile spreading across her face. After spending so much time in crowded, loud towns and on brightly lit, rocking ships, she felt completely at home among the quiet trees. It was peaceful, much like the forests she remembered from her childhood.

She confidently took the lead, guiding the group through the dense bushes and pointing out the broken branches and deep footprints left behind by Ulfrik and his crew.

"They went this way," Eryneth said softly, pointing to a patch of flattened ferns. "There are many heavy boots here. And... smaller prints. Someone was dragging their feet. I think it is the young Prince Gregory."

"How do you do that, Eryneth?" Aknemeia asked, her golden

eyes scanning the forest floor in confusion.

"My mother taught me," Eryneth said with a smile. "Where I come from, in the High Forest, we learn to listen to the trees."

"Wait, you can talk to trees, too?" Szeth asked, surprised. "What's that one named?"

"No," Eryneth chuckled. "I can read the signs of the woods. It's a skill that takes years of practice to master."

"Let's keep moving," Aknemeia said. "We've got to catch up to Ulfrik and his crew."

They followed the trail deeper into the woods, keeping their eyes peeled for any signs of danger. Suddenly, a loud *SNAP* echoed through the trees!



A hidden net made of thick, brittle vines shot up from the forest floor beneath Szeth's feet. But the tall warrior was too quick. With incredible speed, Szeth deftly backflipped out of the net's path, landing gracefully on his feet as the flimsy net snapped harmlessly in the air next to him.

Caryndal clapped his hands in delight. "That is some nimble footwork, my friend."

Szeth brushed a bit of dirt off his shoulder and just shrugged. "It was a very poorly made trap. We made better nets back in my village. But thank you."

Before they could take another step, the branches above them began to shake wildly. *Rustle! Crash!*

A large group of goblins suddenly dropped from the trees, surrounding the heroes in a tight circle! They were small, green creatures with long, pointy ears, and big eyes. They wore oversized clothing that looked like stitched-together rags covered in mud.

They weren't particularly scary, but made up for it in enthusiasm as they shook crude wooden spears and pointed excitedly at Caryndal's beautiful lute and Eryneth's elegant elven cloak.

"Shiny things! We take the shiny things!" one of the goblins shrieked, bouncing up and down.

Caryndal quickly stepped forward, raising his hands with a warm, welcoming smile. A colorful swirl of illusion magic sparkled around his fingers, creating floating, dancing lights in the air to distract the wild horde.



"Greetings, tiny woodland friends!" Caryndal announced theatrically, bowing low to the ground. "There is no need for violence. We are just passing through! We are... The Forest Friends!"

The goblins stopped and stared at the swirling magical lights for a moment. Then, the leader of the goblins hissed angrily and threw a sloppy handful of wet mud right at Caryndal's face. *Splat!*

Eryneth grimaced as Caryndal slowly wiped the mud away, sighing deeply. "Well," Eryneth commented with a nervous laugh. "I don't think that name is going to work."

With that, the goblins charged! It was a fast-paced scramble! The little creatures ran about, poking at the heroes and trying to snatch their belongings. They jumped and tumbled around, pulling on

Szeth's cloak and trying to climb on Caryndal's back to reach his lute. Szeth dashed out of the way, wrestling a few of the goblins away from Caryndal.

"That's enough of that, now get back!" Aknemeia shouted in a magically booming voice. She raised her hands dramatically. A jet of fire shot from her fingertips, blasting a nearby rotten log. *B OOM!*

A loud explosion echoed through the clearing, making the goblins shriek in fear. They began to jump up and down, covering their large ears.

With the goblins distracted, Caryndal strummed a fast-paced, energetic tune on his lute. Magic flowed from his strings, dancing around Eryneth. Her green eyes sharpened as the magic swirled around her. With supernatural speed, she loosed an arrow. *Thwip*. And another *Thwip*. Each arrow flew true, and one by one, the goblins found themselves pinned to the thick tree trunks around the clearing by their oversized, baggy tunics.

Realizing they were trapped and outmatched, the goblins threw down their wooden spears and raised their hands in the air.

"We surrender! We surrender to the sword thieves!" the leader of the goblins cried out, dangling helplessly from a low branch by

his tunic. He wiggled and kicked his short legs.

Aknemeia stopped, tilting her head in pure confusion. She lowered her glowing hands. "Sword thieves? What are you talking about? We didn't steal any swords."

"Yes, you did!" the goblin huffed, crossing his little arms. "Big humans came through here yesterday! They took our special shiny sword! The Beastslayer! Them and that loud, complaining boy!"

The heroes looked at each other, realizing what was going on.

"They think we're with Ulfrik," Eryneth whispered, "and that 'loud boy' must be Prince Gregory."

"I don't even have a beard," Szeth said, crossing his arms and looking at the dangling goblins. "We are not with those thieves," he said flatly. "And even if we were, we wouldn't steal a sword from a bunch of stinky tree-gremlins who don't even know how to tie a proper trap knot."

The goblins gasped loudly in offense. Caryndal gasped too, quickly stepping in before Szeth could make them angry enough to try fighting again.

"What my friend means is," Caryndal said quickly, waving his hands, "we are hunting the men who stole your sword! If you tell us which way they went, we will let you down."

The goblin leader squinted his eyes, thinking for a moment. Then, he pointed a long, green finger deeper into the dark woods. "They went that way, toward the spooky rocks! The old druid place in the middle of the forest!"

"Thank you," Caryndal said with a polite, sweeping bow. He gave Szeth a look that said, *Be nice*.

Eryneth stepped forward and carefully pulled her arrows out of the tree trunks, letting the grumpy goblins drop safely to the mossy ground. As the goblins quickly scrambled away into the bushes, muttering to themselves, the heroes gathered together. They each took a deep, focused breath, and then they set off in the direction provided by the goblins, venturing even deeper into the shadows of the Great Forest.

Chapter 7: The Druid's Grove

The heroes crept carefully through the thick brush of the Great Forest. The trees grew older and the shadows grew deeper until suddenly, the woods opened up into a wide, circular clearing.

This was the ancient Druid's Grove, just like the goblins had said. Giant, moss-covered stone pillars stood in a wide circle, looking like sleepy stone giants watching over the forest. The air felt heavy and tingling with ancient magic.



"Stay low," whispered Szeth, dropping low behind a massive fallen log.

The rest of the heroes quickly ducked behind the log, peering over the rough bark to spy on the center of the clearing.

Standing right in the center of the stone circle was Ulfrik, the fierce captain who had attacked their ship. He looked strong and intense, holding a beautiful, gleaming silver sword in his hands-the stolen Beastslayer.

Beside him stood an older, serious-looking elven man wearing long, flowing robes. He held a wooden staff that hummed with magical energy.

"That must be Audrin," whispered Caryndal. "The one who helped Alicia trap Kazgoroth in the Shards."

Sitting on a flat stone right between them was none other than Prince Gregory.

"And there's our prince," Szeth grumbled quietly. "He's whining as much as usual."

He wasn't tied up, and he didn't look scared at all. Instead, he looked incredibly annoyed.

"This rock is cold," Prince Gregory complained loudly, crossing his arms and pouting. He seemed completely oblivious to the

danger he was in. "And my boots are muddy! I demand a proper velvet chair and a plate of warm cheese tarts!"

Ulfrik rolled his eyes and ignored the boy, turning to the man in the robes. "Are you sure this is going to work, Audrin? Is the boy going to be enough to summon the beast?"

Audrin nodded slowly, his face grim. He began drawing strange symbols in the dirt around Gregory with his staff. "Yes, Ulfrik. Queen Alicia was the conduit for binding Kazgoroth into the Shards. Because Gregory is her son, we can use his bloodline as a magical conduit to draw the beast's spirit out of the Shards and pull it back into the physical world."

"And then," Ulfrik said, running a thumb along the flat edge of the Beastslayer sword, "I will slay it."

"When Queen Alicia, Suhlur, Keane, and I first trapped Kazgoroth, we did not have this sword to defeat him," Audrin said, pointing his staff at the glowing blade. "With this sword, we can finally banish it once and for all."

Prince Gregory stopped complaining about cheese tarts and looked up, his eyes wide. "Wait. You're trying to summon a giant, evil monster right here? Next to me? Isn't that dangerous? What if we fail?"

Ulfrik looked down at the young prince. His eyes were fierce but sad. "The risk is necessary to bring justice for my people," the Northman said firmly. "Kazgoroth's lies tore my people apart. I will not let it hide in a crystal waiting for a chance to escape."

Behind the fallen log, the heroes listened in shock.

Aknemeia grabbed Caryndal's sleeve. "This is terrible!" she whispered. "Summoning Kazgoroth? On purpose? There's no way that's a good idea!"

"She's right," Caryndal said, his voice matching the dim light of the grove. "And if they fail to defeat it, Kazgoroth will be free to cause chaos across the whole island. We can't let them finish this ritual."

Eryneth peered through a gap in the stones. Her keen elven eyes scanned the clearing. "There are too many open spaces. But look over there-the tall grass near that pillar. I can sneak around and get close to the prince."

"Good idea," Caryndal said, reaching for his lute. "I will distract them. Something loud and confusing to draw their attention."

Aknemeia stood up slightly, golden sparks dancing across her knuckles. "And I'll give them a fireworks show."

Szeth nodded, tensing up like a coiled spring. "And I'll grab the boy while they are distracted."

They traded determined nods. It was time to stop a summoning, save a whiny prince, and hopefully, not get squashed by a giant monster in the process.

Chapter 8: The Ritual Interrupted

The heroes huddled behind the massive fallen log, finalizing their daring rescue plan. Eryneth was fixing the string on her bow, and Caryndal was tuning his lute when Audrin stepped towards Prince Gregory in the center of the Druid's Circle.

To the Keepers' surprise, the elven wizard pulled out a dark, pulsing crystal. It was another Shard of Kazgoroth.

"Wait, what?" Aknemeia hissed quietly. "Is he supposed to have one of those?"

"Didn't the queen say Audrin helped her trap Kazgoroth? This must be the last shard..." Caryndal trailed off, his eyes going wide as Audrin set the shard on the ground beside Prince Gregory.

With a loud crack that seemed to echo through the entire forest, Audrin smashed his staff into the shard. The crystal shattered, and the clearing filled with thick black fog and black lightning. The dark energy spun into a vortex, reaching out like smoky fingers toward Prince Gregory in the center of the stone circle. The sky above the ancient clearing rapidly darkened, and the wind began to howl fiercely.

"I think that's our cue!" Caryndal shouted over the roaring wind.

He leaped up onto the fallen log, playing a frantic tune on his lute. Green and gold magical notes exploded from the strings, zipping over to Eryneth and Szeth. The empowered heroes dashed away, alight with magical power.

"I've got the guards!" Aknemeia yelled, throwing her hands forward. She unleashed a dazzling barrage of magical flames. Explosions erupted throughout the clearing, followed by a shower of sticky, glowing magical webs that trapped and confused Ulfrik's raiders.

The clearing descended into chaos, but in the center of the storm, Audrin did not flinch. He tightened his grip on his staff, his eyes locked on the swirling vortex, and continued casting the spell.

"You again?" Ulfrik growled, spotting the heroes through the black smoke and flying spells. He sliced a magical web from the air using the silver Beastslayer sword. "I must admit, your persistence is impressive! But this cannot be stopped. It has to be done!"

"We'll see about that!" Szeth roared, dashing past Ulfrik before the large Northman could react.

Ignoring the dire warnings, the white-clad hero charged headfirst through the magical storm. Eryneth ran with him along the edge of the grove, moving with practiced grace and enchanted speed. The instant one of the raiders escaped from Aknemeia's webs, one of Eryneth's arrows pinned their cloak to the ground or knocked their weapon from their hand, halting them in their tracks.

Szeth weaved through the chaos until he reached the center of the stone circle where Prince Gregory was sitting, surrounded by a swirling vortex of black smoke. The prince, no longer looking bored, was wide-eyed. Black tendrils of smoke seemed to grab at him.

In a flash of white, Szeth arrived, delivering a powerful kick to the tendrils. The smoke fell away, releasing the boy. Szeth grabbed the boy's collar and yanked him out of the swirling magic.

"You're coming with me," Szeth stated, looking the boy in the eyes. For once, Gregory did not whine.

Just as they left the circle, a portion of the swirling black magic formed into a massive reptile tail, smashing into the ground where Gregory had been.

BOOM!

The earth shook, sending everyone tumbling to the ground.

The howling wind became stronger, and dark energy poured relentlessly from where the Shard had broken. As they all watched, the swirling energy solidified, taking on physical form. In a final burst of dark purple energy, Kazgoroth emerged as a colossal reptilian monster!



Kazgoroth let out an ear-splitting roar that shook the remaining leaves from the ancient trees, driving the smoke away.

As they stood up, the heroes looked around to see the scattered raiders surrounding the grove, all of them getting ready to face the impossible beast.

Audrin and Ulfrik stood tall, and Audrin shouted out, "It's time to end this!" The mage raised his staff high, and it began to glow.

Ulfrik held the silver Beastslayer sword high into the air, and looked towards the heroes. "For the Northmen, and for honor!" he roared, his voice filled with fierce determination.

Together, the two former enemies charged toward the towering beast.

From above the grove, Caryndal and Aknemeia surveyed the scene. Caryndal spotted Szeth, who had dragged Gregory safely out of danger and was standing to face the giant reptile.

"I guess we're rescuing Ulfrik and Audrin now?" yelled Caryndal, dusting off his lute. He looked to his side and saw that Aknemeia had conjured a fresh ball of magical fire. She wore a mischievous grin on her face. Eryneth appeared from the other side of the grove, pulling an arrow free from the cloak of one of the raiders she'd pinned earlier. She notched the arrow in her bow, nodding to her friends. "Someone has to stop that thing," she yelled back.

The four of them had started this adventure to rescue a prince, but now they were about to battle a giant, magic reptilian beast. Things, it seemed, didn't always go as planned.

Chapter 9: The Awakened Beast

Kazgoroth unleashed a deafening roar that hit the heroes like a wall. Around the Druid's Grove, tree branches snapped like twigs, and flocks of birds scattered for miles in every direction. The beast was fully formed now, a colossal reptilian monster with armor-like scales and teeth the size of swords. He gave off an evil, purple-black light.

In the center of the grove, Ulfrik and Audrin fell to their knees from the sheer force of the roar.

Audrin fired a blast of magical energy at the beast, which bounced harmlessly off its scales. "My magic isn't strong enough!" Audrin yelled over the howling wind.

"I still have the sword!" Ulfrik shouted back. Before he could raise the Beastslayer, Kazgoroth swung its massive tail. The blow sent Ulfrik flying backward, the silver sword clattering to the muddy ground. Unfortunately, it landed right underneath the beast.

"Did you guys think this through *at all*?!" Szeth yelled from the edge of the grove, brushing a clump of mud from his white clothes.

"We can discuss their poor planning *after* we defeat this monster!" Eryneth shot back. She pulled an arrow from her quiver and tied a rope to it.

Caryndal scrambled up onto a nearby boulder, his lute in hand. "She's right!" he yelled down at the two men. "We'll help you stop this thing, but we're having a *serious* chat afterwards!"

Ulfrik groaned, pulling himself up from the mud. He looked at the massive reptile, then back at the heroes. He gave a single nod, and yelled, "Fine by me! Audrin needs time for a spell, and I need that sword!"

The heroes didn't hesitate.

"Hey, ugly!" Aknemeia shouted, launching herself forward. She thrust her hand toward the creature, and a burst of flames erupted in front of Kazgoroth. The fire took the shape of a dragon as it launched at the beast. The beast thrashed its enormous head in confusion, snapping its jaws at the fire dragon.

At the same time, Caryndal strummed fiercely on his lute. The sounds of an imaginary army echoed around the grove, created from Caryndal's magic. Kazgoroth spun around, its tiny eyes searching for the enemies.

But the beast was relentless. Even confused, it managed to catch Szeth with its massive tail, knocking him backwards.

In a flash of white, Szeth leaped back into the fray. He delivered a powerful flying kick to Kazgoroth's snout, distracting it for a moment longer.

"Now, Eryneth, before I become lunch!" Szeth yelled as he barely escaped a chomp from Kazgoroth's jaws.

Eryneth nodded and fired her bow. One by one, she loosed arrows into the ground around the beast. Each had been tied with elven rope, and they quickly tripped Kazgoroth in a tangle of rope. The beast roared in frustration, trying to free itself, but its own massive weight worked against it. It stumbled!

Thud.

The enormous creature fell to its knees, the ground shaking.

"Ulfrik! This is our chance! Get to the sword!" Audrin yelled. The elf had finished his spell: a jet of pure magical energy shot from his staff into the Beastslayer. The blade, still next to Kazgoroth's feet, began to glow brightly.

Ulfrik was still too far away, struggling to cross the shaking

ground near Kazgoroth. The beast was beginning to tear through Eryneth's nets. He steadied himself on a rock.

"Hold on tight!" Aknemeia yelled. She pointed her hands at the rock Ulfrik was leaning on, and a burst of fire exploded underneath it. The blast launched the rock-and its Northman rider-through the air toward the glowing sword.

Ulfrik's eyes went wide, but he managed to hit the ground rolling near the sword. He reached out and grabbed the Beastslayer. With a final roar of effort, the Northman stood and drove the magical blade straight upwards.



A blast of pure, white light burst from where the blade touched Kazgoroth, matching the purple-black energy pouring from the beast.

Kazgoroth let out a final, earth-shattering roar. Then, in an instant, the colossal monster burst into swirling, dark smoke and purple-black light. Then, the white light of the sword seemed to swallow the dark energy, and the monster was gone.

The howling wind stopped. The ground stopped shaking, and warm, bright sunlight streamed down into the Druid's Grove.

A quiet, heavy silence fell over the clearing. The only sound was the tired breathing of the heroes.

From outside the grove, Prince Gregory peeked his head up over the large rock where he had taken cover. His eyes were wide, and his voice was timid rather than pompous.

"Did... did we win?" the young prince asked.

In the center of the grove, Ulfrik stood alone. The Beastslayer sword was still in his hand, but its glow had faded. The large man looked one-by-one at Aknemeia, Caryndal, Eryneth, and Szeth. After a long pause, Ulfrik spoke. "It... is done," he said, his voice raspy. "Thank you."

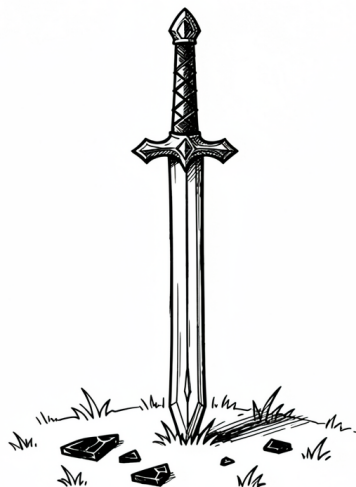
The Keepers looked at one another, took a deep breath, and smiled.

Chapter 10: The Keepers of Mordrin

The silence in the Druid's Grove was almost as loud as Kazgoroth's roar had been moments before. The giant reptilian monster was gone. In the center of the clearing, Ulfrik still held the Beastslayer sword. He turned it in his hands, thinking.

Around the edges of the grove, Aknemeia, Caryndal, Eryneth, and Szeth slowly lowered their weapons. They were covered in dirt and soot, but they were victorious. Prince Gregory, looking shy, was watching from behind his mossy rock.

Ulfrik finally broke the silence. He drove the tip of the Beastslayer into the soft earth and turned to face the four heroes.



"I have fought alongside many warriors," the large Northman rumbled, his voice echoing in the quiet grove. "But I have never seen such bravery and skill as you showed today. You have my gratitude."

Audrin, the elven wizard, stepped up beside Ulfrik and bowed his head respectfully. "It is true. Without your magic and quick thinking, Kazgoroth would have defeated us."

Caryndal rested his lute on his hip, brushing a leaf from his shoulder with a dramatic flair. "Rescuing princes and battling ancient monsters is tough work, but we are professionals, after all."

Eryneth rolled her eyes, but smiled. "We did what had to be done. But..." She looked between Ulfrik and Audrin and shook her head. "Why did you do all of this? Kidnapping the prince, summoning a horrible beast? Why not just ask for help?"

"It was the only way," Audrin replied, with a serious tone. "Kazgoroth was trapped in the shards, but only temporarily. We could not wait for him to escape and cause chaos again. I felt him within my shard, and I knew that one day I would not be able to resist his power."

Ulfrik continued. "If Kazgoroth broke free, it would have been a

danger to all. He tricked my people into a long conflict with his mother, and caused much destruction in the past. We had the opportunity to choose how to fight it this time."

"We needed three things," said Audrin. "Since his mother trapped the beast, Gregory's spirit could draw it out again. Together with my shard, we could summon Kazgoroth... and the Beastslayer could destroy it."

"So you used the prince as bait?" Szeth asked crossing his arms. As always, the white-clad warrior refused to sugarcoat his words. "That is terrible strategy. High Queen Alicia will be furious."

"Exactly," Audrin sighed, looking down. "The Queen would never have agreed to put her son in such danger, even to save the world. And she would never agree to risk freeing Kazgoroth, even with the Beastslayer ready. So we worked in secret. It was a terrible risk, but it was necessary."

Aknemeia crossed her arms, tiny sparks of fire dancing on her fingertips. "It was reckless! You almost lost the battle! What if we hadn't shown up?"

The atmosphere in the grove grew tense. For a long moment, the heroes and the Northman simply stared at one another. Finally, Ulfrik nodded slowly.

"Perhaps you are right," Ulfrik said. "But you came to the call of justice, and the deed is done. The world is now safer." He walked over to Gregory and gently nudged the boy toward the heroes. "You should take the boy home to his mother. If we bring him, we will likely end up in chains." As he turned away, the Northman paused and looked back over his shoulder. "I and my people are in your debt. We leave the sword with you. Use it wisely."

With that, Ulfrik and Audrin gathered the raiders and vanished into the forest.

The heroes enjoyed some tea with Malthos and Florian back at *The Jade Dragon* before setting sail for the High Queen's castle. The journey was long and uneventful, but the peace was a welcome change from fighting a giant beast of primal magic. The gentle sea breeze and the sound of the waves were soothing.

After three days at sea, they finally spotted the royal castle through the morning mist. "I bet my mother will throw a feast," Gregory said, rushing to the ship's rail. He had been unusually quiet on the journey home, though he still complained about his damp socks and the lack of fine cheese.

"I hope so," said Szeth. "I haven't had a proper meal since we met you!"

When the group finally reached the royal palace, they were immediately rushed into the grand throne room. High Queen Alicia Kendrick leaped from her throne and sprinted down the steps, pulling her son into a tight hug.

"Gregory!" she cried. "I am so glad you are safe!"

"Mother!" Gregory said, hugging the queen. "You wouldn't believe what happened! These people fought a giant lizard monster, and then it exploded!"

The High Queen turned to the four heroes, smiling warmly. "You have done the impossible," she said. "You found Ulfrik, rescued my son, and banished Kazgoroth. The Kendrick family, and the entire Kingdom, thank you for your heroism. From this day forward, your organization is honored in this realm." She paused, and waved to a woman with a pen and ink. "Take note of this royal favor: in all lands of the realm, these heroes are to be granted safe passage and hospitality..." She paused, looking at the four of them. "What is your organization called, exactly?"

"Ahem, one moment," said Caryndal, turning quietly to his friends. "Well? All I know is you didn't like the Clamshell

Avengers, or The Shard Snatchers, or The Forest Friends."

Szeth shook his head. "Right, yeah, those were terrible."

"Well, do you have a better idea?" Caryndal said. "We're kind of on the hook here."

Szeth looked out over the city for a moment, thinking. Then he pulled a cage out of his bag and opened it. A small, black raven flew out and landed on his shoulder. "Remember Mordrin? Suhlur's... pet? I kept him," said Szeth. "so... how about The Keepers of Mordrin? He can be our mascot."

The others exchanged a look.

"I kind of like it," Eryneth agreed, a smile spreading across her face.

Aknemeia shrugged. "It'll do, I guess."

"Fine," Caryndal nodded, and with a bow and flourish, he turned to the queen. "Your Majesty, we are The Keepers of Mordrin."

That evening, the palace threw a celebration more grand than anything the heroes had ever seen. The tables were piled high with roasted meats, fresh fruits, and, to Gregory's delight, the absolute finest cheeses in the land. Musicians played lively tunes in the corner, though Caryndal made sure to pull out his lute and show them how it was *really* done.



Later in the evening, the four friends found themselves standing together on a balcony, overlooking the twinkling lights of the city below. The night air was cool and refreshing.

"So," Eryneth said softly, looking at her companions. "We rescued the prince. What comes next?"

Aknemeia smiled, her fiery golden eyes sparkling in the moonlight. "Whatever it is, I'm sure we can handle it. I'm in no

hurry to get back to Baldur's Gate." Her friends looked at her, curious. "My dad is a strange fellow. I'll tell you another time, when I'm ready."

They were quiet for a moment, until Szeth spoke up. "Well, since we're talking about our pasts, does anyone know where I can find a bad guy with a big black sword?"

And so the Keepers of Mordrin talked, late into the night, about the past and the future.